

Chapter 91-4

That evening, Liang Shi sent a text message to Gu Xingyue asking if it was convenient to call.

Gu Xingyue replied: [Not convenient. Just send a message.]

Liang Shi didn't let down her guard. She was worried that Yang Jiani might be the one holding Gu Xingyue's phone and replying. So she suggested to Gu Xingyue that they add each other on WeChat, saying she wanted to ask about Rainbow's usual performance at school.

She did it flawlessly. Then Gu Xingyue added her on WeChat and sent the first message: [Rainbow usually performs very well. It's just that today she was trapped in the sports equipment room. She might be traumatized, so please remember to comfort her tonight.]

Rainbow was trapped in the equipment room?

Trapped?

Those two words were quite telling.

Liang Shi replied: [Okay, thank you, Teacher Qi. Sorry to trouble you.]

She immediately called Zhou Li to verify with Rainbow. Rainbow said firmly: "I wasn't trapped at all. We didn't have PE class today, but a boy from the older class was playing soccer and kicked our classroom window and shattered it."

Liang Shi acknowledged this and asked her a few more everyday questions, which Rainbow answered one by one.

Before she could ask about Qi Jiao's recent situation, Rainbow took the initiative to say: "Sister Liang, does Teacher Qi have something on her mind lately?"

"What's wrong?" Liang Shi asked.

Rainbow said in confusion: "She was drinking alcohol in the office. There was alcohol in her water cup... And the day before yesterday during class, she suddenly cried."

Liang Shi was surprised: "The day before yesterday?"

Wasn't that the day before Gu Xingyue called her?

"Yeah, her whole eyes were red from crying." Rainbow sighed. "We all tried to comfort her, but it didn't work. It seems like she experienced something major..."

Liang Shi said in a low voice: "I understand. Thank you, Rainbow."

"Oh right." Rainbow said: "There's one more thing."

"What?" Liang Shi asked.

"Last week Teacher Qi came to class limping." Rainbow said: "She said she bumped into something, but I saw marks on her ankle, very much like marks from being tied with nylon rope."

"Nylon rope?!" Liang Shi and Zhou Li exclaimed in surprise at the same time.

Liang Shi was surprised because she felt that Yang Jiani would absolutely do such a crazy thing, but she was also surprised that Rainbow could accurately describe something like nylon rope.

Zhou Li was surprised because using nylon rope to tie someone—that was clearly a crime!

"Are you sure?" Liang Shi still hadn't completely accepted Rainbow's genius girl persona. After all, she was only a five-year-old child. Ling Dang didn't even know what nylon rope was right now, yet Rainbow could already accurately describe objects based on marks. So to be safe, she asked again.

Rainbow said: "Not entirely sure, but I feel it's either nylon rope or binding cord, because I only saw it briefly and couldn't look carefully."

Zhou Li said in a low voice from the side: "You can trust her judgment. Her... father is a mystery enthusiast."

This was the first time Liang Shi had heard Zhou Li mention Rainbow's father. Rainbow had mentioned before that her father was abroad and that she was mixed-race.

But since Zhou Li said so, Liang Shi believed it.

Rainbow's judgment had never been wrong.

After verifying with Rainbow, Liang Shi looked at her phone screen. It still showed her conversation with Gu Xingyue.

Gu Xingyue said Rainbow was trapped in the sports equipment room today, but Rainbow said someone had shattered their classroom window today.

—This should be the information Gu Xingyue was trying to convey.

She didn't dare act rashly now.

While she was carefully thinking through the connections, Xu Qingzhu had just finished washing up and came out of the bathroom. She was holding a towel drying her hair and casually asked about Gu Xingyue's situation.

Liang Shi immediately spilled everything like beans pouring from a bamboo tube. Xu Qingzhu: "?"

"Don't you need to hesitate at all?" Xu Qingzhu said: "This is after all a very confidential matter."

Liang Shi: "..."

"Do I need to with you?" Liang Shi urged: "Teacher Xu, you're smarter. Help me figure this out. All I can think of is that Gu Xingyue is trapped, but if she was really locked up, she wouldn't be able to send me messages. So what's the correct information she's trying to convey to me?"

Xu Qingzhu walked to the sofa and sat down on the carpet, leaning against the sofa. The towel was casually draped over her shoulder. Her half-wet hair was sticking up and she hadn't had time to tidy it. Instead, she took out a piece of paper from the cabinet and asked Liang Shi for her phone.

Liang Shi opened the chat page and placed it in front of her. After Xu Qingzhu scrolled through, she copied down those few sentences.

Then she asked Liang Shi word by word what Rainbow had said.

As Liang Shi spoke, Xu Qingzhu recorded.

While speaking, Liang Shi picked up the towel from Xu Qingzhu's shoulder and started drying her hair.

Xu Qingzhu suddenly drew in a sharp breath. Liang Shi's movements paused: "What's wrong? Did you figure it out?"

"You pulled so hard my scalp went numb." Xu Qingzhu said: "Do you think I could have figured it out yet?"

Liang Shi: "..."

She slowed down her movements and said in a low voice: "Sorry."

Xu Qingzhu continued looking down and piecing together these bits of information. Liang Shi helped her dry her hair while also thinking.

A few seconds later, both of them suddenly spoke at the same time: "Gu Xingyue tried to resist but was discovered by Yang Jiani?!"

Xu Qingzhu turned around, and the two of them made eye contact.

Then Liang Shi indicated for Xu Qingzhu to speak while she listened quietly.

Xu Qingzhu connected all these information points together: "It was originally a destructive incident of shattering glass, but Gu Xingyue said Rainbow was trapped in the sports equipment room. So she's telling us that if she's locked up, she's very likely locked in a place with a lot of miscellaneous items. And Rainbow said her leg was injured a few days ago with marks on her ankle, indicating she was recently abused. Why would Yang Jiani abuse her? Because she did some destructive things, such as resisting, and was discovered by Yang Jiani, so Yang Jiani abused her again."

"Also, why would she suddenly cry during class? As a teacher, crying during class is a big taboo." Xu Qingzhu was a bit puzzled here. "She's already suffered Yang Jiani's long-term abuse, so she shouldn't react to this kind of thing. She wouldn't cry in class just because of being abused. So what major event affected her? And drinking alcohol in her water cup—this rebellious behavior suddenly happening to her, could it be related to Director Gu and the others?"

But Liang Shi suddenly thought of someone. She pressed her lips together: "Perhaps it's also related to other things."

She took out her phone to check her blacklist. Just as she was about to remove Cheng Can's number from the blacklist, a call from an unknown number came through.

Liang Shi answered. Xu Qingzhu stayed quiet, but her head moved in Liang Shi's hand, indicating she should continue drying her hair.

Liang Shi dried her hair with one hand and answered the phone with the other: "Hello?"

The voice on the other end was somewhat garbled, and the background was noisy. She couldn't make out what was being said. Liang Shi put it on speaker and told the other party: "I can't hear clearly."

Suddenly, an angry roar erupted from the other side: "Everyone shut the fuck up!"

Liang Shi with the speakerphone on: "..."

She and Xu Qingzhu were both startled at the same time. Xu Qingzhu's resentful gaze turned toward her. Liang Shi gently patted her head to soothe her.

Xu Qingzhu continued sitting on the carpet with her arms crossed. Both of them recognized who was on the other end.

After Cheng Can's roar, when she spoke again her voice was hoarse: "Hello?"

Liang Shi quickly said: "I'm here."

"Damn." Cheng Can clicked her tongue. "Liang Shi, you're being so well-behaved. I'm really not used to it."

Liang Shi: "..."

"Say what you need to say quickly. If there's nothing, I'm hanging up." Liang Shi said irritably.

Now Cheng Can was comfortable. She spoke extremely fast, sounding a bit embarrassed, but it was too garbled—you had to really work hard to make out what she was saying: "Have you seen Qi Jiao recently?"

Liang Shi: "..."

Liang Shi was silent for a few seconds, then said coldly: "Can you speak normally?"

Cheng Can: "...I'm asking if you've seen Qi Jiao recently. Don't you know her?"

Liang Shi: "You tell me first—did you break up with Qi Jiao? Or did she catch you fooling around with another woman?"

There was two seconds of silence on Cheng Can's end, then the sound of lighting a cigarette: "Damn, really can't hide anything from you."

Liang Shi: "..."

Liang Shi gritted her teeth: "So which one is it?"

Cheng Can paused: "Both. The day before yesterday she came to find me, and I was... and then she broke up with me."

Liang Shi: "..."

Cheng Can scoffed lightly: "But the problem is she already broke up with me once before. After we got back together, we haven't even met once. I have some needs, you know... Liang Shi, you should understand."

Liang Shi couldn't help but curse: "...I understand jack shit."¹

Footnotes:

¹ **I understand jack shit (我懂個屁):** A crude colloquial expression literally meaning "I understand a fart," used to emphatically deny understanding or agreement with something ridiculous. The vulgarity emphasizes Liang Shi's frustration and complete rejection of Cheng Can's excuse.